

DAY 06

Phishing Email Investigation

SOC L1 Portfolio Report | Synthetic Training Scenario

Analyst	MD Mostakim Hossain
Case ID	PHISH-2026-001
Classification	Confirmed Credential Phishing
Severity / Status	Medium / Closed

Executive Summary

A user-reported email impersonating Microsoft 365 was investigated and confirmed as credential phishing. The user did not interact with the message. The email was quarantined, associated indicators were blocked, an environment-wide mailbox search was completed, and no compromise was observed.

Scope and Safety

This report documents a fully synthetic training scenario. All domains use the reserved .example namespace and all URLs are defanged.

Alert Details

Field	Observed Value
Targeted User	employee@northstarfinance.com
Display Name	Microsoft Security
From	security@micros0ft-support.example
Reply-To	verify.account@outlook-security-check.example
Subject	Urgent: Your Microsoft 365 account will be suspended today
Defanged URL	hxxps://microsoft.login-check.example/verify
Attachment	Microsoft_Account_Verification.html

Authentication Results

Control	Result	Analyst Interpretation
SPF	Fail	Sending server was not authorized for the claimed domain
DKIM	None	No DKIM signature was present
DMARC	Fail	Authentication and domain alignment requirements were not met

Key Findings

- The sender used the lookalike domain micros0ft-support.example, replacing the letter o with the number 0.
- The From and Reply-To domains did not match.
- The message used urgency and threatened account suspension within 30 minutes.
- The apparent Microsoft link resolved to the non-Microsoft main domain login-check.example.
- The HTML attachment was consistent with a credential-harvesting login page.
- SPF and DMARC failed, and no DKIM signature was present.

Five Ws

Category	Finding
Who	Target: employee@northstarfinance.com; reported sender: security@microsoft-support.example
What	Microsoft 365 impersonation using a misleading URL and HTML credential-harvesting attachment
When	Received 10:15 AM; reported 10:22 AM; triage began 10:25 AM EDT on September 21, 2026
Where	Northstar Finance Microsoft 365 email environment
Why	Correlated sender, URL, attachment, social-engineering, and authentication indicators confirmed phishing

Timeline

Time (EDT)	Event
10:15 AM	Phishing email received
10:22 AM	Employee reported the message
10:25 AM	SOC triage initiated
10:32 AM	Sender, URL, attachment, and authentication indicators analyzed
10:40 AM	Message quarantined and indicators blocked
10:47 AM	Organization-wide mailbox search completed
10:55 AM	No user impact observed; case closed

User Impact

Check	Result
Link clicked	No
Attachment opened	No
Credentials submitted	No
Account or endpoint compromise	None observed

Containment and Response

- Quarantined the phishing email from the targeted mailbox.
- Blocked the malicious sender, domains, URL, and relevant indicators.
- Searched the Microsoft 365 environment for additional copies.
- Quarantined any matching messages identified during the tenant-wide search.
- Documented findings, timestamps, verdict, user impact, and response actions.

Disposition

Field	Decision
Verdict	Confirmed Credential Phishing
Severity	Medium
Impact	No observed user, account, or endpoint compromise
Final Status	Closed

Closure Rationale

The malicious email was contained, associated indicators were blocked, the wider email environment was searched, and the user confirmed no interaction. No remaining investigative or containment actions were identified.

MITRE ATT&CK Mapping

Technique	ID	Observed Behavior
Phishing: Spearphishing Link	T1566.002	Misleading verification link
Phishing: Spearphishing Attachment	T1566.001	HTML attachment
Input Capture: Web Portal Capture	T1056.003	Suspected fake login form

Analyst Takeaways

- Correlate multiple indicators before assigning a final verdict.
- Separate confirmed malicious intent from observed business impact.
- Verify user interaction before choosing containment and recovery actions.
- Search the full email environment rather than treating one mailbox in isolation.